

queen of Halicarnassus (modern-day Turkey), commanded five ships during the second Persian invasion of Greece. Medieval female pirates of any form were rare, and mostly Scandinavian, including the Danish queen Alfhild. Norse sagas refer to female longship captains such as Hetha, who became queen of Zeeland in the 8th century. She was one of several maritime heroines with “bodies of women and souls of men,” who were cast by male writers as acceptably loyal rather than outsiders.

Renowned pirate Grace O'Malley (see right) assumed leadership of a 16th-century seafaring dynasty in west Ireland after her father died. Previously he had refused to allow her to accompany him on an expedition because her long hair could get caught in the ship's ropes, so she had cut off all her hair (earning the nickname Granuaile, meaning cropped hair).

The “Golden Age” of piracy (1650–1726) featured around eight known women pirates. Most were British or American—all were white. Operating in the Caribbean and off America's east coast, they heisted lucrative cargoes during piracy outbursts against Britain, France, and Spain. Anne Bonny and Mary Read achieved the greatest notoriety thanks to the romanticized bestseller *A General History of the Pyrates* (1724).

Modern piracy

In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, Chinese women pirates came to the fore. At least two rose from poverty to command large fleets of junks after their husbands died. Female and male pirates alike were hard-hearted toward captives—Lo Hon-Cho's 64 junks captured young women then sold them as sex slaves in the 1920s. Today, women are mostly involved in piracy from land, away from the Somali-dominated business at sea. Office-based, these women pass on intelligence about cargo ships, fence goods, and process ransom emails.



▲ Marauder queen

A picture of the 18th-century Irish American pirate Anne Bonny, who joined the crew of “Calico Jack” Rackham in the Caribbean. She did not disguise her gender from her shipmates but dressed as a male when pillaging.



PROFILES

NOTABLE WOMEN PIRATES

Artemisia (c. 480 BCE) is often regarded as the first woman pirate. As a widow, this Greek Queen of the ancient city-state of Halicarnassus led five ships in the Greco-Persian wars. Her daring maneuvers led her ally, Persian King Xerxes I, to praise her courage and declare she was made of the substance of a man.

Jeanne de Clisson (1300–1359), the daughter of a French nobleman, led a fleet against the merchant vessels of King Philip VI of France to avenge her husband's execution. Known as the Lioness of Brittany, she attacked French ships in the English Channel, raided French villages, and carried supplies for the English army.

Sayyida al Hurra (1485–1561) was a 16th-century Moroccan queen who turned to piracy against Christian enemies to avenge the ousting of her Muslim family from Granada. The acknowledged leader of piracy in the western Mediterranean—but seemingly not seagoing—she was well-respected for her capabilities.

Grace O'Malley (c. 1530–c. 1603) was known as the Pirate Queen of Ireland. The chieftain of a wealthy Irish clan, she plundered at land and sea over four decades of privateering (licensed piracy), sailing as far as Portugal. She never hid her gender, wearing dresses and even giving birth at sea. After she promised Queen Elizabeth I she would reform her ways, her son was made a viscount.

Mary Read (c. 1690–c. 1720) dressed as a boy from a very young age in order to wangle payments from her dead father's family, join armies, and live as a man. In her twenties she became a privateer, then a pirate, under Captain “Calico Jack” Rackham. She and her shipmate Anne Bonny sailed for about two years. When captured, they evaded execution by claiming they were pregnant. Mary died in prison from illness or in childbirth in 1721.

Ching Shih (1775–1844) was a former Canton sex worker in Qing China who married pirate Cheng I, leader of the Red Flag Fleet, and sailed with him in the South China Seas. When he died in 1807 she assumed leadership and commanded 70,000 men and 400 junks (traditional Chinese sailing ships). She negotiated an amnesty with the Chinese authorities and later ran a gambling house.